

Lecture 11: The Physics of Fission

CBE 30235: Introduction to Nuclear Engineering — D. T. Leighton

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1 Introduction: The Destination

In Lecture 10, we discussed the "Journey" of the neutron: slowing down from 2 MeV to 0.025 eV, avoiding resonance traps, and thermalizing. Today, we discuss the "Destination": **Fission**.

What exactly happens when a thermal neutron strikes a uranium nucleus? How does the nucleus split? And most importantly for engineers, where specifically does the energy come from?

2 The Liquid Drop Model (Bohr & Wheeler, 1939)

To understand the mechanics of fission, we model the heavy nucleus not as a collection of hard spheres, but as a drop of incompressible, charged fluid. The stability of this drop is determined by a tug-of-war between two fundamental forces:

1. **Nuclear Force (Surface Tension):** The strong nuclear force acts between nearest neighbors. Just like surface tension in a water drop, this force tries to keep the nucleus spherical (minimizing surface area).
2. **Coulomb Force (Repulsion):** The nucleus contains 92 protons (for Uranium) all repelling each other. This force tries to tear the nucleus apart.

2.1 The Activation Energy

In a stable nucleus like ^{235}U (well, almost stable anyway), the surface tension is just strong enough to contain the Coulomb repulsion. However, the equilibrium is fragile.

- When a neutron is absorbed, it adds **Binding Energy** (~ 6 MeV) and (if unmoderated) kinetic energy to the system.
- This energy excites the nucleus, causing it to vibrate and oscillate.
- If the oscillation deforms the sphere into a "dumbbell" or peanut shape, the Coulomb distance between the two lobes increases, but the surface tension (neck area) decreases.
- **Critical Deformation:** Once the nucleus stretches past a certain point, the Coulomb repulsion between the two lobes overcomes the restoring force of the surface tension. The split becomes inevitable.

3 The Dynamics of "The Snap"

The actual moment of separation is violent and complex. As Chemical Engineers, we can visualize this using a familiar fluid dynamics analogy.

3.1 The "Satellite Droplet" Analogy

Consider the breakup of a viscous liquid jet or a dripping faucet. As the drop stretches, a thin fluid "neck" forms between the two main lobes. Due to the Rayleigh-Plateau instability, this neck eventually snaps.

1. **In Fluid Mechanics:** When the neck breaks, the fluid contained within it does not simply vanish. It often breaks up into tiny, secondary droplets known as **Satellite Droplets** that are found between the two main drops.
2. **In Nuclear Fission:** The "nuclear fluid" in the neck behaves identically. When the neck snaps, the nucleons in that region are left stranded. They are ejected immediately as free neutrons.

This mechanism gives rise to the **Prompt Neutrons** (ν) that sustain our chain reaction. They come from two distinct sources during the snap:

- **Scission Neutrons (~10%):** These are the "satellite droplets" ejected directly from the snapping neck at the moment of separation ($t \approx 10^{-20}$ s).
- **Evaporation Neutrons (~90%):** Immediately after the snap, the two large fragments are highly deformed and incredibly "hot." As they relax into spherical shapes, they "boil off" excess neutrons to cool down ($t \approx 10^{-17}$ s).

Result: On average, the fission of ^{235}U releases $\nu \approx 2.43$ neutrons.

4 The Semi-Empirical Mass Formula (SEMF) (*Lamarsh, 2.12*)

To understand why some isotopes fission and others do not, we must quantify the nuclear binding energy. We use the **Semi-Empirical Mass Formula (SEMF)**, based on the Liquid Drop Model proposed by George Gamow and refined by Weizsäcker.

The binding energy $B(A, Z)$ is approximated by five distinct physical terms:

$$B(A, Z) = \underbrace{a_v A}_{\text{Volume}} - \underbrace{a_s A^{2/3}}_{\text{Surface}} - \underbrace{a_c \frac{Z(Z-1)}{A^{1/3}}}_{\text{Coulomb}} - \underbrace{a_{\text{sym}} \frac{(N-Z)^2}{A}}_{\text{Asymmetry}} + \underbrace{\delta(A, Z)}_{\text{Pairing}} \quad (1)$$

Physical Interpretation of the Terms

1. **Volume Term ($a_v A$):** The strong nuclear force is short-range and saturates. Each nucleon interacts only with its nearest neighbors. Thus, the binding energy is directly proportional to the volume (or total mass number A).
2. **Surface Term ($-a_s A^{2/3}$):** Nucleons on the surface of the "drop" have fewer neighbors than those in the center. This reduces the total binding energy. This effect is proportional to the surface area ($4\pi R^2 \propto A^{2/3}$).

3. **Coulomb Term** ($-a_c Z^2/A^{1/3}$): The protons repel each other due to the electromagnetic force. This instability grows with the square of the proton number (Z^2) and decreases as the nucleus gets larger (inversely proportional to radius $A^{1/3}$).
4. **Asymmetry Term** ($-a_{sym}(N - Z)^2/A$): Due to the Pauli Exclusion Principle, the nucleus is most stable when $N \approx Z$. Having a large excess of neutrons or protons forces nucleons into higher energy states, reducing the binding energy.
5. **Pairing Term** (δ): Nucleons have a strong tendency to couple in pairs (spin-up with spin-down). This term dictates the **fissile** nature of an isotope:

$$\delta(A, Z) = \begin{cases} +\Delta & \text{for Even-Even nuclei (Most Stable)} \\ 0 & \text{for Odd-Mass nuclei (e.g., } ^{235}\text{U, } ^{239}\text{Pu)} \\ -\Delta & \text{for Odd-Odd nuclei (Least Stable)} \end{cases} \quad (2)$$

It is this **Pairing Term** that creates the "odd-even" effect, explaining why adding a neutron to an odd nucleus (like ^{235}U) releases more energy than adding one to an even nucleus (like ^{238}U).

5 Fissile vs. Fissionable

Now that we understand the Liquid Drop mechanism and the Semi-Empirical Mass Formula (SEMF), we can use these tools to explain the physical difference between **fissile** and **fissionable** isotopes. The distinction lies in the **Pairing Energy** term (δ) of the nuclear binding energy.

When a nucleus captures a neutron, the excitation energy (E_{ex}) of the resulting compound nucleus comes from two sources:

$$E_{ex} = \underbrace{S_n}_{\text{Separation Energy}} + \underbrace{E_k}_{\text{Neutron Kinetic Energy}} \quad (3)$$

For fission to occur, this excitation energy must exceed the critical fission barrier (E_{crit}).

- **Fissile Isotopes (e.g., ^{235}U , ^{239}Pu):**

These isotopes have an **Odd** number of neutrons. When they absorb a neutron, they become **Even-Even** nuclei. This formation releases a massive "Pairing Energy" bonus, resulting in a very high Neutron Separation Energy (S_n).

For ^{235}U , $S_n \approx 6.5$ MeV, which is **greater** than the fission barrier ($E_{crit} \approx 5.9$ MeV).

Result: The neutron needs zero kinetic energy ($E_k \approx 0$). Fission occurs with **thermal** neutrons.

- **Fissionable (Threshold) Isotopes (e.g., ^{238}U):**

These isotopes already have an **Even** number of neutrons. When they absorb a neutron, they become **Even-Odd** nuclei. They do *not* receive the pairing bonus.

For ^{238}U , the separation energy is only $S_n \approx 4.8$ MeV, which is **lower** than the barrier ($E_{crit} \approx 5.9$ MeV). The drop vibrates, but does not break.

Result: To overcome the barrier, the incoming neutron must supply the deficit via kinetic energy ($E_k > 1$ MeV). Fission is a **threshold** reaction.

Summary Definition: A *fissile* isotope fissions with thermal neutrons (due to pairing energy), while a *fissionable* isotope requires a high-energy "kick" to split. Note that all fissile isotopes are fissionable, but not all fissionable isotopes are fissile.

Table 1: Thermal Neutron Fission Yield (ν) for Common Fissile Isotopes

Isotope	Symbol	Origin	Thermal ν
Uranium-233	^{233}U	Bred from Thorium (^{232}Th)	2.49
Uranium-235	^{235}U	Natural (0.7% of Natural U)	2.42
Plutonium-239	^{239}Pu	Bred from Uranium (^{238}U)	2.87
Plutonium-241	^{241}Pu	Bred from Plutonium (^{240}Pu)	2.93

Table 2: Important Threshold Fissionable (Fertile) Isotopes

Isotope	Threshold	Role in Reactor
Uranium-238 (^{238}U)	~ 1.1 MeV	Dominant fuel component (95%+); breeds ^{239}Pu via capture.
Thorium-232 (^{232}Th)	~ 1.3 MeV	Foundation of the Thorium cycle; breeds ^{233}U via capture.
Plutonium-240 (^{240}Pu)	~ 0.6 MeV	Accumulates in high-burnup fuel; breeds ^{241}Pu . Note the lower threshold.
Uranium-236 (^{236}U)	~ 0.9 MeV	Parasitic buildup from ^{235}U capture; penalizes neutron economy.

Practical Implications: Fast Fission and Fertility

While threshold isotopes cannot sustain a chain reaction on their own (since most fission neutrons are quickly slowed below 1 MeV), they still play two critical roles in reactor physics:

1. **The Fast Fission Bonus (ϵ):** Fission neutrons are born at high energies (average ≈ 2 MeV). Before they slow down, they have a chance to strike a ^{238}U nucleus and cause fission. In a typical Light Water Reactor, this accounts for 3–5% of all fissions, providing a small but valuable multiplier to the neutron population.
2. **Fertile vs. Parasitic:** Most threshold isotopes are **Fertile**, meaning their capture product leads to a new fissile fuel (e.g., $^{238}\text{U} \rightarrow ^{239}\text{Pu}$). However, some, like ^{236}U , are purely **Parasitic**. ^{236}U is formed when ^{235}U captures a neutron without fissioning. It acts as a neutron poison, absorbing neutrons to become the long-lived waste product ^{237}Np , without contributing to breeding useful fuel.

6 The Products of Fission

Fission is rarely symmetric. The nucleus does not split into two equal halves ($A \approx 118$). Instead, quantum mechanical shell effects cause it to split asymmetrically.

6.1 The Mass Yield Curve

If we plot the probability of producing a fragment of mass A , we see a distinctive "double-humped" curve (the Camel Plot).

- **Light Peak:** Centered around $A \approx 95$ (e.g., Strontium, Krypton).
- **Heavy Peak:** Centered around $A \approx 140$ (e.g., Xenon, Cesium, Iodine).

- **The Valley:** Symmetric fission ($A \approx 118$) is very rare (probability drop of $\sim 600\times$).

6.2 Why are they Radioactive?

The heavy nucleus (^{235}U) has a huge neutron-to-proton ratio (~ 1.55) to overcome Coulomb repulsion. Stable light elements ($A \approx 100$) prefer a ratio closer to 1.3.

- When the nucleus splits, the fragments inherit the "parent's" neutron-heavy ratio even accounting for the losses from scission and evaporation.
- They are **Neutron Rich** (far too many neutrons for stability).
- To stabilize, they must convert neutrons into protons via **Beta Decay** (β^-). This is the source of the intense radioactivity of nuclear waste.

7 The Energy Balance (Where is the heat?)

We often quote the energy release of fission as **200 MeV**. As engineers, we need to know exactly where this energy is deposited to design our heat transfer systems.

Energy Form	Approx. Energy	Range	Recoverable?
1. KE of Fission Fragments	168 MeV	$\sim 10\mu\text{m}$	Yes (Fuel)
2. KE of Neutrons	5 MeV	cm to m	Yes (Moderator)
3. Prompt Gamma Rays	7 MeV	m	Yes (Shield/Structure)
4. Decay Heat (Betas/Gammas)	$\sim 15\text{--}20$ MeV	N/A	Yes (Delayed)
5. Neutrinos	10–12 MeV	∞	No (Lost)
Total Recoverable Heat	$\approx 190\text{--}200$ MeV		

Table 3: Distribution of Fission Energy

Key Engineering Insights:

- **The Fuel Gets Hot:** Over 80% of the energy (Item 1) is Kinetic Energy of the heavy fragments. Because these are highly charged, they interact strongly with matter and stop within micrometers. *All this heat is generated inside the fuel pellet.*
- **The Moderator Gets Warm:** The neutron kinetic energy (Item 2) is deposited in the water/graphite as they slow down.
- **Safety:** Item 4 (Decay Heat) is generated *after* the fission event, over seconds, days, and years. Even if the reactor is shut down, this heat source remains. This is the driver for all meltdown scenarios (e.g., Fukushima).

8 Prompt vs. Delayed Neutrons

While 99.35% of neutrons are "Prompt" (emitted at the moment of fission), a tiny fraction ($\beta \approx 0.0065$) are "Delayed."

- **Origin:** Certain fission products (precursors) undergo beta decay and *then* emit a neutron seconds later.

- **Significance:** If all neutrons were prompt, the reactor would respond to changes in 10^{-4} seconds—too fast to control. The delayed neutrons increase the average "generation time" to effectively seconds, allowing human/mechanical control.

9 Defining the Multiplication Factors

We have discussed how neutrons are born (ν) and how they interact. To model a reactor, we must convert these physical processes into probabilities. This leads us to the definitions found in Lamarsh Section 3.7.

9.1 The Reproduction Factor (η)

We know that ν neutrons are produced per *fission*. However, not every neutron absorbed by the fuel causes fission; some are merely captured (n, γ). We define η (eta) as the number of fission neutrons produced per **absorption** in the fuel:

$$\eta = \nu \frac{\sigma_f}{\sigma_a} = \nu \frac{\sigma_f}{\sigma_f + \sigma_\gamma} \quad (4)$$

For pure ^{235}U , $\eta \approx 2.08$. For natural uranium (mostly ^{238}U , which absorbs but doesn't fission), $\eta \approx 1.3$. This drop is why we need enrichment.

9.2 The Fast Fission Factor (ϵ)

Fission neutrons are born fast (2 MeV). Before they leave the fuel rod, they have a small chance of striking a ^{238}U nucleus and causing a "fast fission" event (as discussed in Section 4).

- This creates a small "bonus" to our neutron population.
- ϵ is defined as the ratio of total fission neutrons to those produced by thermal fission alone.
- Typically, $\epsilon \approx 1.03$ (a 3% bonus).

9.3 The Resonance Escape Probability (p)

As the neutron slows down, it must pass through the "Valley of Death" (the resonance region of ^{238}U) discussed in Lecture 10.

- p is the probability that a neutron successfully reaches thermal energy without being captured in a resonance.
- In a typical LWR, $p \approx 0.7$ (meaning 30% of neutrons are lost here).

9.4 The Thermal Utilization Factor (f)

Once thermalized, the neutron will eventually be absorbed. But will it be absorbed by the fuel (useful) or by the water/steel/control rods (waste)?

$$f = \frac{\Sigma_{a,fuel}}{\Sigma_{a,total}} \quad (5)$$

This is the ratio of absorption in the fuel to total absorption in the reactor.

10 Looking Ahead

We have now rigorously defined the four key factors: η, ϵ, p, f . In **Lecture 12 (Monday)**, we will multiply these together to derive the **Four Factor Formula** (and combining them with the finite reactor geometry obtain the Six Factor Formula) to calculate k_{eff} and determine if our reactor is Critical, Supercritical, or Subcritical.

References

1. Lamarsh, J. R., & Baratta, A. J. *Introduction to Nuclear Engineering*, 4th Ed. Pearson, 2017. (Section 3.7 & 2.12).
2. Bethe, H. A., & Bacher, R. F. “Nuclear Physics A. Stationary States of Nuclei.” *Rev. Mod. Phys.* **8**, 82 (1936). <https://journals.aps.org/rmp/abstract/10.1103/RevModPhys.8.82>
3. Bohr, N., & Wheeler, J. A. “The Mechanism of Nuclear Fission.” *Phys. Rev.* **56**, 426 (1939).